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It was a nervous wait for the USA cricket team. The start of a crucial Group A match against Ireland at Lauderhill was delayed due to a wet outfield. Then the rain came down hard, bringing relief and joy. The washed-out encounter was enough to give co-host USA a spot in the Super 8 stage of the ICC Men's T20 World Cup.

AT 17, HARMEET SINGH (RIGHT) MADE HIS FIRST-CLASS DEBUT FOR MUMBAI

The minnows are the toast of the tournament — a most unexpected success story made possible by immigrant dreams that has captured the attention of mainstream media and the public in the country. The average American has every reason to be proud. The squad has a distinct *desi* flavour — no less than seven members have their roots in India.

The rest of the team has cricketers from Pakistan (Ali Khan) and the West Indies. Ali, especially, has made a remarkable impact, taking crucial wickets in this tournament. He was also instrumental in the team's series win against Bangladesh prior to the World Cup.

Among the Indian-origin cricketers, a true star has emerged. Saurabh Netravalkar captured headlines back home when he bowled a tight Super Over to stun Pakistan in a group stage match in Grand Prairie (Texas). The win over Pakistan shocked the world and contributed significantly to the two-time World T20 champion's early exit from the tournament.

Like many others in the USA team, Netravalkar earned his cricket stripes in India. The left-arm fast bowler from Mumbai represented India in the 2010 Under-19 World Cup, playing alongside K.L. Rahul and Mayank Agarwal. However, gaining a spot in the Mumbai team proved to be a tough task. The strong Mumbai unit had stalwarts like Zaheer Khan, Dhawal Kulkarni, and Ajit Agarkar, which meant that Netravalkar could manage just one First-Class cap.

A disappointed Netravalkar gave up on his cricket dreams and moved to the USA to pursue a Master's degree. But at a local match, he caught the attention of Pubudu Dassanayake, the USA's national team coach. This was a turning point, as Netravalkar worked his way into the USA team. Now, on the grand stage of the World Cup, he is making the most of his second innings. Netravalkar still holds a steady job at Oracle, making his story all the more

Dual impact: Besides his World Cup heroics, Saurabh Netravalkar still holds a steady job at Oracle, making his story all the more relatable for those in the corporate world. K. R. DEEPAK



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